



Consultative Conversations for Support Advocates

Transform your support approach from transactional to relationship-driven

Training Module by Kyle Mohny

What You'll Master Today

01

Consultative vs. Transactional

Understanding the fundamental difference in support approaches

02

Essential Techniques

Active listening, empathy, and conversation control methods

03

RRA Framework

Repeat, Reaffirm, Acknowledge - your escalation game-changer

04

Structured Call Flow

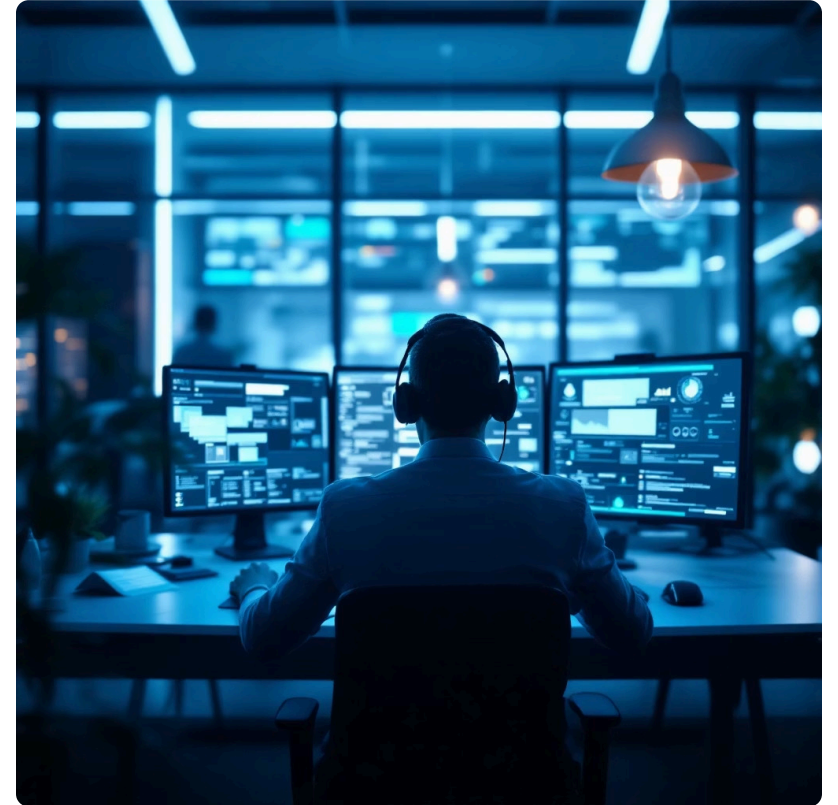
If-then logic for handling pushbacks and difficult conversations

From Frontline to Leadership

Kyle Mohny started as a frontline support rep at HomeAdvisor, promoted to Supervisor within one year. At Thumbtack, he became the **sole national escalation manager** for two years.

Every "I want a supervisor" call across the country came directly to him. This experience taught him how consultative conversations turn tense moments into trust-building opportunities.

 **Key Insight:** Building strong support systems can make you indispensable - and sometimes replaceable. Success in operations is both the goal and the risk.





Why Consultative Conversations Matter

Builds Trust

Customers feel heard and valued, not just processed through a system

Reduces Escalations

Address root causes and emotions, preventing repeat calls and complaints

Creates Long-term Value

Transforms frustrated customers into loyal advocates for your brand

Transactional support closes tickets. Consultative support builds relationships that make tomorrow easier for everyone.

Essential Conversation Techniques



Active Listening

Filter noise, find the real problem. Customers often share ten things before revealing the actual issue.



Open-Ended Probes

"Can you walk me through what led to this?" uncovers the full picture before you act.



Professional Empathy

"I can see why that would be frustrating" builds rapport without admitting fault.



Educate & Guide

Explain policies and options. Understanding lowers resistance to difficult news.

Voice & Presence Techniques

Over the Pencil

Project your voice over an imaginary pencil one inch from your lips. Creates clarity and authority without shouting.

Posture + Smile

Sit upright with shoulders back. A slight smile adds warmth. Your posture directly shapes your vocal tone.

Match Their Pace

Fast talkers are anxious - slow down to calm them. Slow speakers need patience - mirror their rhythm.



📌 **Pro Tip:** This "over the pencil" technique comes from vocal coach Melissa Cross, who trained major artists like Slipknot and Stone Sour.

Professional Empathy vs. Apologies

Empathy builds trust; hollow apologies destroy it. Know the difference.

Say This

"I understand why that would be frustrating."

"I can see how that impacts your workflow."

Not This

"Sorry, sorry, sorry about that."

"I apologize for the inconvenience."

Only apologize when your company or employee is actually at fault.
Professional empathy shows understanding without admitting unnecessary blame.



The Power of Ask to Ask

Transform transactional support into consultative education with this simple technique.

"May I share something that might help explain why this works this way?"

Once they say yes, they're far more likely to hear you out without interruption. This shifts the conversation from problem-solving to customer education.





The RRA Method

This three-step approach transforms how customers perceive your support interaction.

Repeat

State their specific pain point back to them. Pause and let them confirm or correct you.

Reaffirm

Show empathy without over-apologizing. "I understand why that would be frustrating."

Acknowledge

Outline next steps with a review, not a promise. Set clear expectations.



Perfect RRA in Action

"You're calling because of an unexpected charge? I completely understand! No one likes being charged without realizing it. Let's take a look at this situation together and see what I can do to help out!"

Repeat + Reaffirm + Acknowledge in one exchange



Specific

Addresses their exact pain point



Empathetic

Shows understanding without blame



Actionable

Clear next steps without false promises

The Support Call Flow Framework

Every customer support call follows a predictable rhythm. Think of it as a decision tree—if the customer goes one way, you know exactly how to respond.

01

Customer Shares Pain Point

Listen fully before jumping in. Let them vent for 30-60 seconds before stating the actual problem.

02

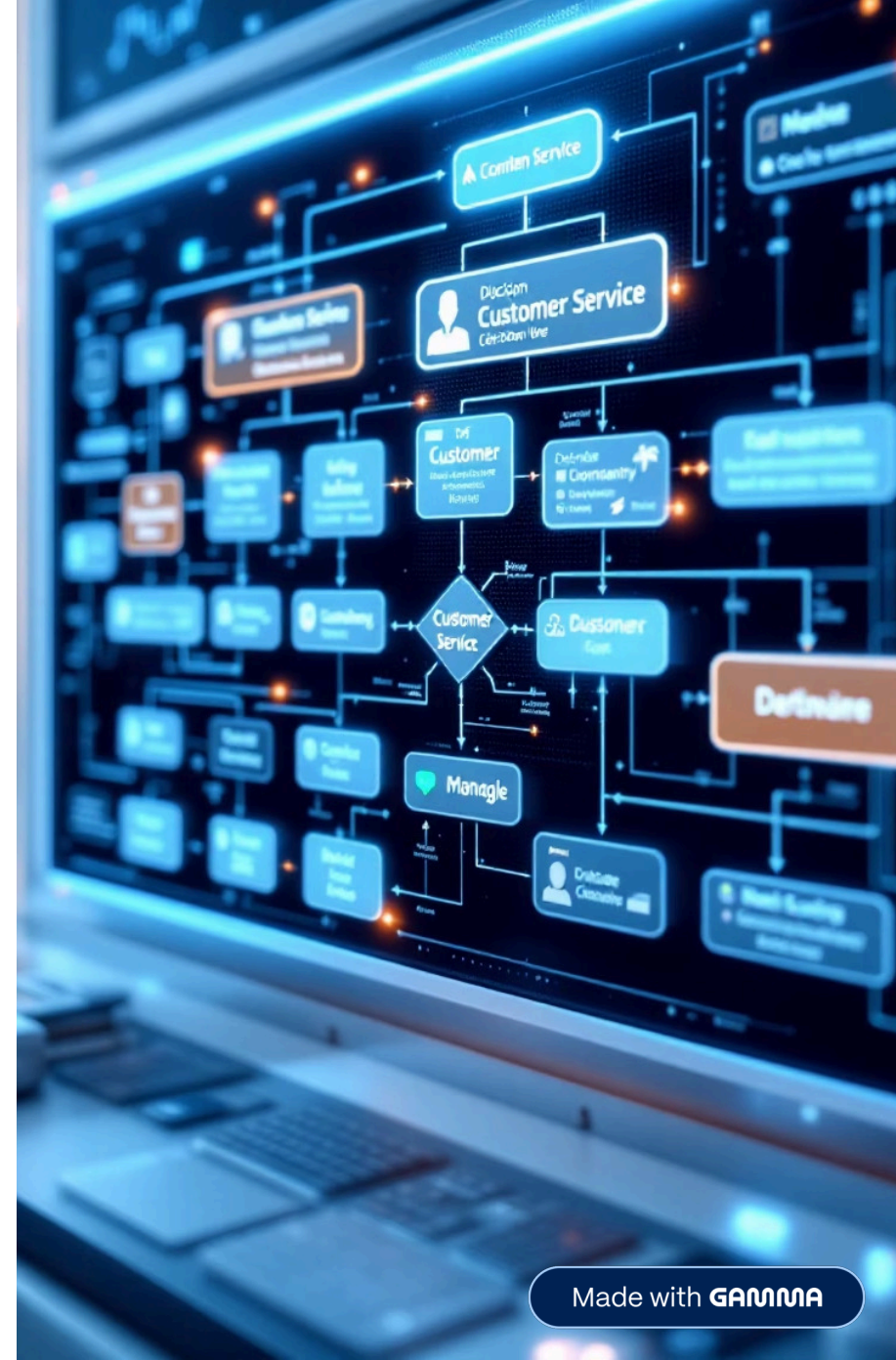
Apply RRA Method

Repeat, Reaffirm, Acknowledge. This ensures customers feel heard and dramatically lowers escalation risk.

03

Provide First Answer

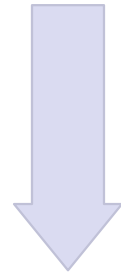
Deliver your explanation clearly and neutrally. Keep it short and focused on resolution.





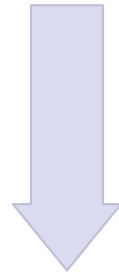
Handling Pushback Like a Pro

When customers resist your initial answer, follow this escalation ladder to maintain control while building trust.



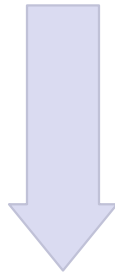
Pushback 1: Explain in Detail

Break down the answer step-by-step using simple, relatable language. Keep tone calm and professional.



Pushback 2: Reaffirm & Redirect

Restate concisely, then pivot toward ROI or overall experience to focus on long-term value.



Pushback 3: Final Answer

Thank them for feedback, reiterate the answer won't change, attempt one last value redirect.

Three Possible Outcomes

Not every call ends with a happy customer—and that's okay. Success means maximizing trust and minimizing damage.

1

Best Case: Value Conversation

Customer accepts your answer and discusses overall experience. Opens doors for upsells and identifying churn risks.

2

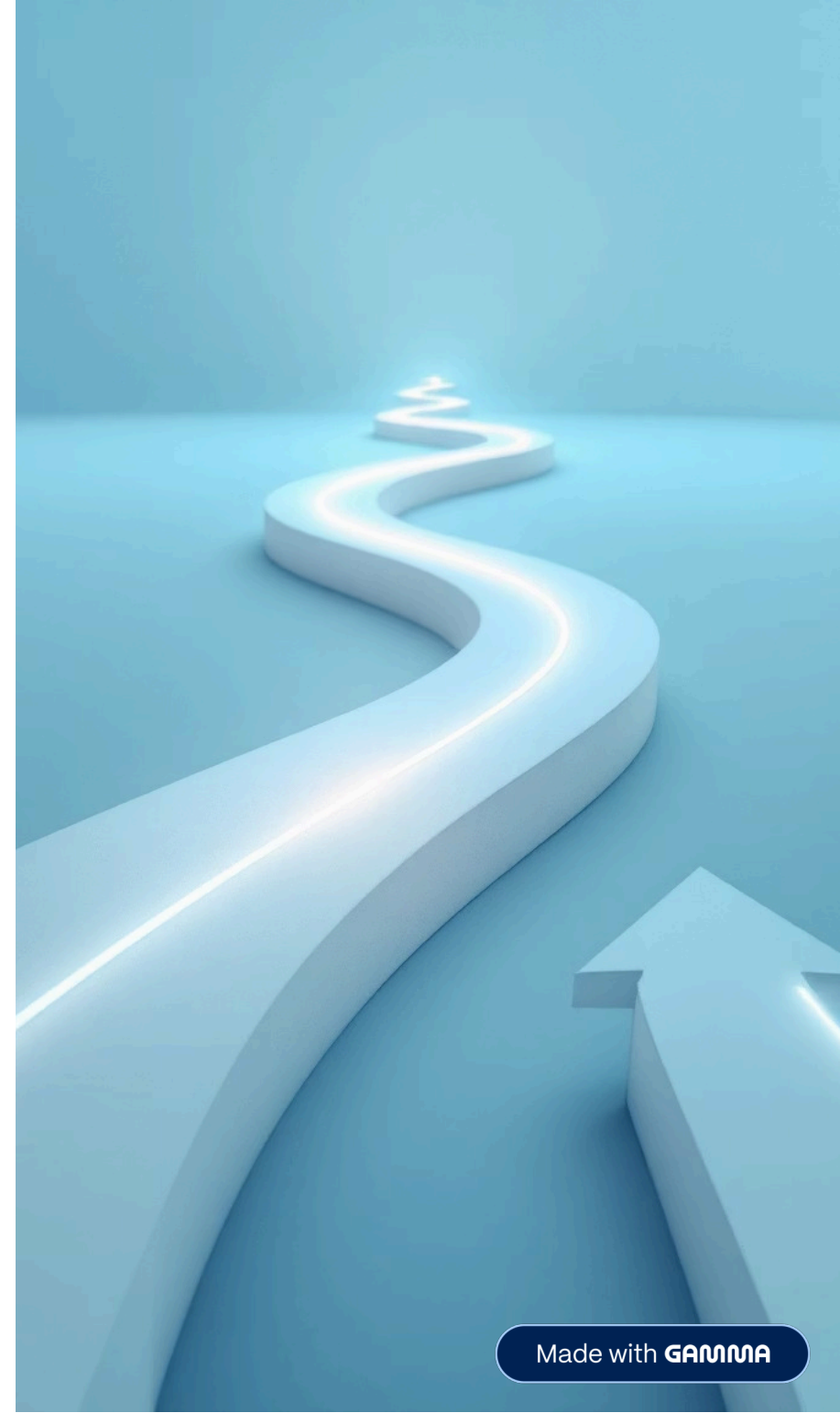
Middle Case: Grudging Acceptance

Customer accepts explanation without engagement. Call ends without escalation—still a support win.

3

Escalation: Supervisor Request

Follow protocol professionally. Frame handoff as additional expertise, not failure.





Key Performance Indicators

Consultative conversations deliver measurable improvements across critical support metrics.

40%

Fewer Escalations

Structured approach
reduces unnecessary
supervisor requests

60%

Less Repeat Contacts

Thorough explanations
prevent callback loops

85%

Higher Trust Scores

Customers feel heard
and respected
throughout interaction

Transform Every Conversation

Consultative support doesn't just resolve today's issue - it makes tomorrow easier for both customer and company.

Practice RRA in daily conversations

These techniques work beyond customer service - try them with colleagues, friends, and family

Remember: Side-by-side, not face-to-face

Empathy statements shift you from opposition to collaboration with every customer

Build trust, reduce escalations, create value

Every conversation is an opportunity to strengthen customer relationships





Common Challenges & Solutions

Customer Keeps Repeating

Use RRA, then escalate through detail levels. After third cycle, give resolute final answer.

Don't Know the Answer

Be honest: "That's a great question—let me find out for you."
Customers respect honesty.

Customer Won't Stop Interrupting

Use "Ask to Ask" or place on brief hold. Return with immediate answer they wouldn't let you give.

Angry Customer Won't Calm Down

Stay composed. Let them vent, then respond with serious empathy. Use silence strategically.

Your Role as Support Advocate

Consultative conversations don't take more time—they take more intentionality. You're not just solving problems; you're creating trust and long-term success.



Build Trust

Every interaction strengthens customer confidence in your brand



Ensure Consistency

Structured approach delivers reliable experience across all touchpoints



Drive Success

Transform frustrated customers into advocates through intentional communication

Master these techniques and you'll spend less time de-escalating, more time having constructive conversations.

